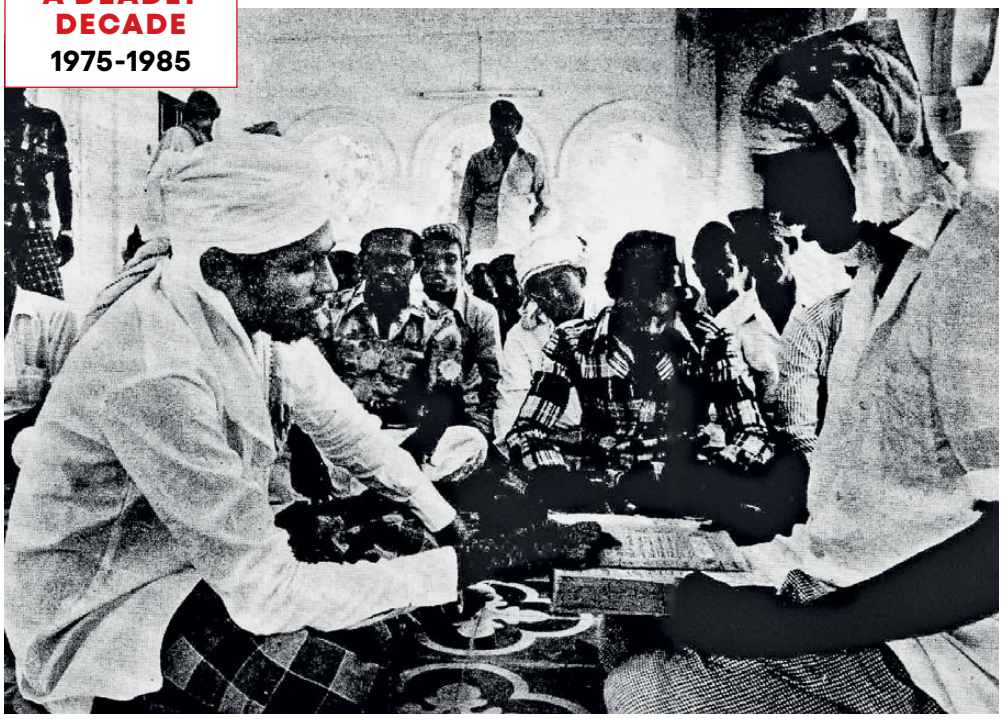
GHAR WAPSI Below, Dalits at the conversion ceremony in a mosque in Meenakshipuram, Tamil Nadu, Sept. 1981; Right, some of the victims of the Nellie massacre in Assam, Feb. 1983





RAGHU RAI

COMMUNAL CONFLICT

FEAR AND LOATHING

As the communal climate warmed dramatically in the 1980s, caste was added to the mix in the controversy over the mass conversion of Tamil Dalits to Islam. In Assam, a student-led 'anti-outsider' agitation combined with tribal sentiments to spark a shocking massacre of Bengali Muslims

There were several flashpoints in the tumultuous decade that was the 1980s. On February 19, 1981, around 180 families (or 1,100 people as per the government estimate) from the Pallar community, a scheduled caste, converted from Hinduism to Islam at a mass conversion ceremony in Tamil Nadu's Meenakshipuram village. Considered untouchables, they worked primarily as low-income agricultural labourers. The conversions sent shockwaves across the country. It was alleged that they were forced and foreign funded. Several politicians visited the village, including Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Eventually, most of the converts returned to Hinduism, citing unfulfilled promises. The conversions had a ripple effect—the BJP raised the issue in Parliament in 1984, possibly adding momentum to the Ayodhya movement. Rather more grim was the Nellie Massa-